

FIELD OF VISION | SHARDA UGRA

Dear Sports Minister,



Welcome to the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports. Now, don't feel too bad. Usually, unfortunately being named Sports Minister is like being put in charge of the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation; family and friends just don't know whether to distribute the *laddoos* or to call for a condolence meeting.

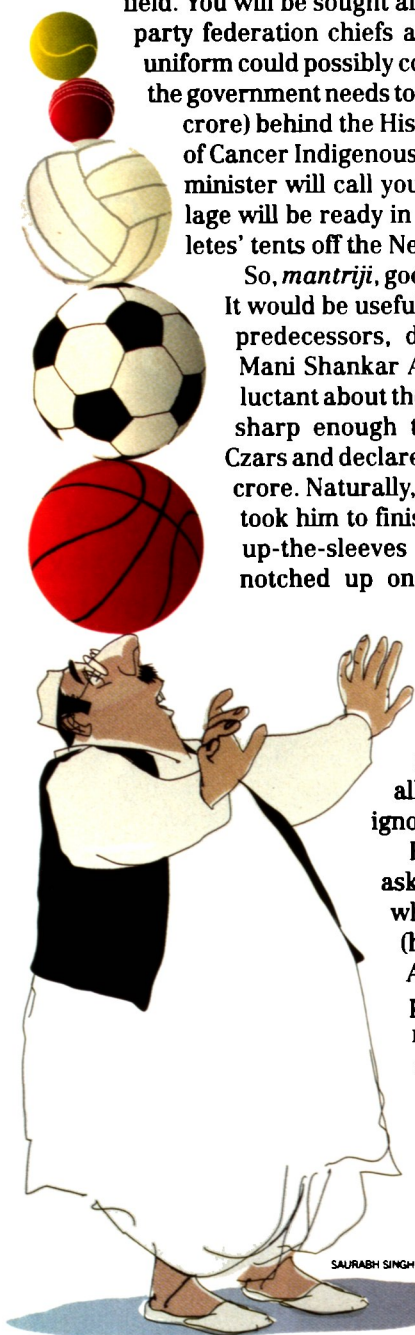
This year though, all is different. The MYAS (no, it's not ever called My-As for short) is the best seat in the house because in 2010, India hosts the Commonwealth Games (CWG), our biggest sports event since the 1982 Asiad. That means you are standing on centre-field. You will be sought after by the IOA All-Czars (more on them later), multi-party federation chiefs and the cameras. You will decide whether our CWG uniform could possibly cost Rs 15 crore and whether the government needs to put its weight (and Rs 1,500 crore) behind the Historic 1st-Ever World Tropic of Cancer Indigenous Peoples Games. The prime minister will call you often to see if the CWG village will be ready in time to move all those athletes' tents off the Nehru Stadium turf.

So, *mantriji*, good luck for that little project. It would be useful if you call your immediate predecessors, delightful gentlemen both. Mani Shankar Aiyar admitted to being reluctant about the *khel-kud* business but was sharp enough to see through the IOA-All Czars and declare the CWG a waste of Rs 6,000 crore. Naturally, he didn't last longer than it took him to finish that sentence. His successor M.S. Gill was a roll-up-the-sleeves and get-straight-to-the-soundbite-kinda guy, who notched up one really staggering achievement—he sacked his namesake, the seriously disoriented KPS, who believed Indian hockey was an insurgency movement that needed swift crushing. Gill has also asked for the Arjuna Award trophy to be redesigned and streamlined, the sign of a man with an aesthetic sense. (Pity he couldn't do much about the sensationally vulgar IPL trophy but those cricket people can be ignored, they don't ask for hand-outs.)

Pay very close attention to every hand-out you are asked for, especially by the IOA All-Czars, led by two men who cannot see eye to eye but share a common cause (hoodwinking you) along with the federations chiefs. All come with enviable survival skills and diligent practice in fund-siphoning, media propaganda scare-mongering. Should you ask the most logical of questions (*How come you're still around? Where's all that money we gave you?*) they will tell you they cannot answer because then India will be expelled from the Olympic movement. To amuse yourself, call their bluff once.

Finally, we can only hope to God you are not Suresh Kalmadi, and wish you all the best. Yours sincerely, etc...

THIS YEAR, ALL IS DIFFERENT. YOU ARE STANDING ON CENTRE-FIELD. YOU'LL BE SOUGHT AFTER BY THE IOA ALL-CZARS, FEDERATION CHIEFS AND THE CAMERAS.



CONVICTED: Judicial magistrate S.S. Bhargava to six years imprisonment for corruption. He had been trapped by the CBI



while taking a bribe in 2003. This is the first time a judge has been convicted.

APPOINTED: Balwinder Singh as additional director in the Central Bureau of Investigation. A 1976-batch IPS officer, he had a previous stint in the CBI from 1999 to 2000.

WON: By pugilist Nanao Singh, the gold at the training-cum-competition event in Almaty, Kazakhstan. Indian boxers won four medals at the event.

APPOINTED: Om Prakash, India's ambassador to Finland, as the new envoy to Estonia.

CONVICTED: Ram Gosh, former deputy director-general in the Telecom Ministry, for amassing disproportionate assets worth over Rs 20 lakh.

